GRILLED TOFU VEGGIE TACOS *(with pesto)*

Super yummy take on soft tacos with a delicious green goddess dressing. My favorite part is the eggplant, can't wait to see what parts you like best!

Origin

Tacos originated in pre-Columbian Mexico, where indigenous peoples—including the Aztecs—used flat, nixtamalized corn tortillas as edible spoons to hold fillings like fish, beans, and chiles. The word "taco" itself comes from the Nahuatl word *tlahco*, meaning "half" or "in the middle".

Pesto origin – Pesto originated in the Ligurian city of Genoa, northern region of Italy, in the 16th century. The word comes from the Italian verb *pestare* (meaning to pound or crush). It's true ancestor is the ancient Roman *moretum*, a pounded paste of herbs, garlic, and cheese

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At a Glance

- **Prep Time:** Estimated time, 20 mins
- **Cook Time:** Estimated time, 20 minutes
- **Servings:** Number of servings, 6-8

Preparation – *Mis en place –Everything in its place*

Tasks to complete before the main cooking begins to ensure a smooth process.

- **Chop/Dice:** eggplant, mushrooms, spinach, tofu, red onion
- **Grill or griddle** veggies and tofu
- **Assemble Tools:** griddle and or grill

Ingredients

Primary Plant Protein/Base:

- tofu - firm

Fresh Produce & Aromatics:

- Spinach
- 1 large eggplant
- 1 red onion
- 2 packages mushrooms – sliced
- 2 avocados

Marinade for Tofu

- 3 garlic cloves finely chopped
- 1 tsp red pepper flakes
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp ponzu

Pesto

- 2 cups packed fresh basil (large stems removed)
- 3 cloves of garlic
- 2 tbs lemon juice
- 4 tbs nutritional yeast
- 2 tbs extra virgin oil
- 4 tbs water (plus more as needed)
- ¼ tsp salt (plus more to taste)

Pantry Staples & Seasonings:

- Garlic powder
- Salt
- Pepper

🔪 Directions

Clear, sequential steps to guide the cooking process. Cook in "layers"

Prepare

1. Marinade tofu. Then begin slicing and dicing vegetables.

Pre- cook vegetables and tofu – griddle/grill

1. Slice eggplant about 1/4 inch thick
2. Slice mushrooms
3. Roughly chop spinach
4. Slice red onion thin
5. Slice avocado thin
6. Use Olive oil spray with a little salt and pepper and grill/griddle the vegetables in batches.
7. Do the same process for the tofu
8. Set aside all veggies and tofu,

Now it is time to make the dressing

Make the pesto dressing:

1. Put all ingredients in the blender and blend thoroughly
2. Taste and adjust salt or acidity as needed

Make the burritos

1. Spread pesto on the burrito
2. Add tofu, and add layer in the vegetables
3. Fold over like a burrito
4. Spray griddle with olive oil. Place on griddle / griddle on both side
5. Cut in half

💡 Quick Tips

Bonus advice for variations, efficiency, and sustainability.

- **Flavor Boost:** can add a spicy taco seasoning to the tofu.
- **Substitution:** can replace eggplant with zucchini. Can use mini or large tortillas
- **Meal Prep Hack:** can last for a couple of days in the refrigerator. Great for appetizers. Can replace with a green goddess dressing for many things – salad, dips and a replacement for mayonnaise.

Nutritional Information

Estimated values per ½ cup

Tofu	90-144 calories per 100g, 10-14 g protein, 7 g fiber, 2g low carbs, Fat - heart-healthy polyunsaturated fat, 0 cholesterol. Includes calcium, manganese, iron, copper, selenium, phosphorus, magnesium, zinc and vitamins A, B1, B2 and B5
Eggplant	20 calories: .8 g protein: 2.5 g fiber: .1 g fat: 4.8 gm carb for 1 cup Eggplant is a nutrient-dense, low-calorie nightshade vegetable. It is highly regarded for its heart and brain benefits, primarily driven by powerful antioxidants found in its deep purple skin
Mushroom	28 calories for 1 cup, 2.9 protein, 1.1 g carbs, and .3 g fat. Has high B complex vitamins and D2. Also, high in antioxidants, may help lower cholesterol, may help regulate blood sugar and may help support your immune
Spinach	7 Calories, 0.9 g protein: .4 gm carbs: .2 g fiber: .7 g fiber for 1 cup Spinach is a nutrient-dense, low-calorie superfood. It is an excellent source of vitamins K, A, and folate
Avocado	160 Calories (per 100g), 2 g protein, 1.9 g ,7 g fiber, 7 g fiber, 8.5 g Carbohydrates, Healthy Fats: ~14.7–15g. Most of this is monounsaturated fat (oleic acid), which supports heart health and reduces "bad" LDL cholesterol, Provides 20 different vitamins and minerals, notably: Potassium, Vitamin K, Folate, B9, vitamins C, E, and B6, magnesium & copper)
Basil	1 calorie per 2 tbs. Basil provides a wealth of health benefits, acting as a nutrient powerhouse packed with antioxidants, vitamins (Vitamin K), and essential oils. It actively reduces inflammation, supports heart and digestive health, and can help alleviate stress
Nutritional Yeast	40-60 cal per 2 Tbs, 4-5 g protein, 3-5 g carbs, 2-3 fiber, 0 fat, 0 sugar. Nutritional yeast, often called "nooch," is a nutrient-dense seasoning popular in vegan and vegetarian diets for its nutty, cheesy flavor. It is an excellent source of plant-based protein, dietary fiber, and B vitamins (especially B12) while remaining naturally fat-free and low in calories

What is tofu and is it good for you?

Tofu is a nutrient-dense, plant-based protein made from curdled soy milk pressed into blocks, offering a complete amino acid profile, high iron, and calcium. It is generally considered very healthy, supporting heart health, reducing risk of certain cancers, and aiding weight management. It is low-fat, cholesterol free, and safe for daily consumption.
It is a nutrient-dense, plant-based complete protein containing all nine essential amino acids required by the body. Its nutritional profile varies primarily by its firmness; firmer varieties generally contain more protein, fat, and calories per serving because they have less water content.

- **Extra-Firm Tofu:** provides 15-17 g of protein, and 145 calories
- **Firm Tofu:** provides 8–10g of protein and 70-80 calories
- **Silken/Soft Tofu:** Higher in water content, providing about 4–7g of protein and 40–62 calories

Key Health Benefits

- **Heart Health:** Tofu is cholesterol-free, low in saturated fat, and may help reduce LDL cholesterol. Studies show eating at least one serving per week may lower heart disease risk by 18%.
- **Nutrient-Rich:** It is a good source of iron, manganese, selenium, phosphorus, and calcium, especially when made with calcium-sulfate.
- **Cancer Risk Reduction:** Tofu contains isoflavones, which have antioxidants, anti-inflammatory, and potential protective effects against breast, prostate, and colorectal cancers.
- **Bone Health:** The high calcium and magnesium content helps prevent osteoporosis.

Is tofu good for you?

Yes, edamame is highly nutritious and good for you. These young soybeans are a complete, plant-based protein packed with fiber, iron, and essential nutrients like vitamin K and folate. They support heart health, aid in blood sugar regulation, and may help with weight management.

Are soy products good for you?

Yes, soy products are generally considered very good for you, offering a nutrient-dense, plant-based protein source that can lower cholesterol and reduce heart disease risk. Whole soy foods like tofu, edamame, and tempeh are packed with isoflavones and fiber, making them a healthy alternative to red meat.

What is nutritional yeast and is it good for you?

Nutritional yeast is a deactivated yeast used as a food product. It comes from the *Saccharomyces cerevisiae* species, which is the same type used to bake bread or brew beer. However, its yeast cells are killed during processing, meaning it will not make bread rise or ferment liquids.

Nutritional yeast is exceptionally good for you, offering a dense concentration of plant-based protein, dietary fiber, and essential B vitamins for very few calories. It is widely considered a functional superfood, particularly for individuals following vegan, vegetarian, or plant-based diets